50 in a direct transfer in his bank, then he remembers it, as opposed to the thousands of crores you spend on the public. That no one cares about or remembers at the time of elections. This creation of personal labharthees was crucial and we worked very hard to politically mobilise this with labharthee sammelans.'[20]

A Lucknow journalist argued, 'You can make roads paved with silver and gold but nothing will happen [in terms of votes]. It is about what you get personally. That is what matters and this is why cash transfers changed the game.' A senior functionary recounted a telling conversation with a roadside cobbler, who plied his trade opposite a doctor's clinic in Lucknow, just before the 2019 elections. When asked who would win, the cobbler unequivocally replied: 'Modi'. Why, asked the questioner, who was also carrying out a survey of twenty Jatavs each in several constituencies. The cobbler himself was a 'haathi-waala' (BSP supporter; the haathi, or elephant, is the party's poll symbol). So, why did he think Modi would win?

'Yes, I will vote for haathi,' he said, 'but in my village, one person has got a house [money for one] from the government.'

Did he get a house himself?

'No,' said the cobbler. 'But I will get it. I have ummeed [hope].'

The cobbler was a diehard BSP supporter, but he had seen people in his village benefiting, and thought that he too could benefit at some stage. The possibility made him more receptive to the party.[21]

DBT and the BJP's Targeted Meetings

Yet, if spending money on welfare alone was enough to win back power, then few democratic governments anywhere would lose power. DBT as a policy tool is not some secret weapon. Liberal economists have been aggressively recommending it for years, and state governments cutting across party lines, like the TRS in Telangana and the Kamal Nath-led Congress government in Madhya Pradesh (2018–2020), have all deployed them.[22] This brings us to the second major shift that the BJP made. The party skilfully deployed its grassroots organisation, which had been reshaped in 2013, as a tool to specifically target labharthees. It combined